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Zeke Mullins

At the time of this interview, Zeke Mullins had begun his eighth decade as a jazz pianist. Zeke performed with The Lionel Hampton Band for twenty years, and became a member of The Harlem Blues and Jazz Band in 2015.

Zeke was interviewed in New Hartford, New York on June 9, 2017, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are near Clinton, NY. I'm pleased to be talking with pianist Zeke Mullins today. Welcome.

ZM: Thank you.

MR: And tomorrow, or later today, you'll be playing up at Hamilton with the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band.

ZM: Yes.

MR: How long have you been working with these guys?

ZM: Well let me see now, this June it's been about oh maybe five or maybe six months. We kind of got into lock with each other. Let me see, how did it happen? The gentleman that formed the band, Al Vollmer, he's a physician, dentist. And somehow or another me and him, we sort of, I guess you might say bumped each other. You know.

MR: Yeah.

ZM: And he just liked the way I played. And we got together. And it's been a very easy band, very easy and what I might say — professionally exciting band playing with these guys. When I get on the bandstand with them it's never no, lot of friction or a lot of, you know, blah-blah-blah stuff going on. It's always for all we know we're there to play music. And that's what everybody does, with the intention of trying to sound and play as well as they can.

MR: You grew up at a time where there was no such thing as going to school to learn jazz.

ZM: No. No there wasn't.

MR: How did you learn how to play it?

ZM: Well actually by, I don't know, I guess we just bumped into each other because I officially started playing piano at seven years old, I started studying classical music. My people are from the West Indies and their hopes were for me to probably become a concert pianist you know, at the time that was not easily reached you know. But I kept going, and I started when I was about seven, and I studied until I was in my teens. I think I was about 15. And I just, all of a sudden I got kind of tired of playing, you might say, of the music. And I just stopped. And there was a lot of friction going on between me and my mother and my father you know. They were not too pleased with me at the time. But

after a while they just relented into the thing you know. I stopped playing for about a whole year. And within that time I started hearing, late at night, jazz wasn't what you might say a thing that was on the radio or, it was recorded and everything, but it was more or less sort of a background thing. And let's see, I started hearing it, little bits of it at night like around maybe 9, 8:30, 9, 10 o'clock in that area like, for maybe sometimes 15 minutes or half an hour you know. And I, you know, hadn't played it or hadn't been connected with it, it sounded good to me. The feeling. The what you might say, yeah, the feeling that it gave me. I said gee I like that. And I even went and bought some books and sort of tried to, you might say, set myself up musically with the music you know. Meaning that, I figured that way, if I did that then just playing after a while would come naturally, which it did.

MR: Do you recall who you were hearing at the time on the radio?

ZM: Well let's see. I think Benny Goodman was probably — he was one of the top, I'd say top musicians playing. He wasn't actually playing jazz though, he was playing swing, which, it sounded close to jazz. And I used to listen to his band you know, with Teddy Wilson playing piano. And he had that extra group, a sextet I think it was, and Lionel Hampton was in that group. And I mean it really excited me. You know I started talking about this, and well my mother and father, I have to confess they weren't really into this like I was.

MR: You're going from Beethoven to Teddy Wilson, right?

ZM: It was a long ways. But you know I just kept it up. And a lot of the stuff that I came from, I taught myself you know? Because I bought these books. I could play scales and stuff, but then I came to realize that the chords in jazz were built on the scales. So if you understood your scale then it really wasn't that hard to understand the distance of the notes playing chords you know.

Excuse me [gets up]

Because the guys would say you play the right single notes but you don't play the right chords.

And so you listen to how it sounds you know. And so I followed their suggestion and it took me quite a while, those chords, they're not as easy — you say chords but there are so many of them.

MR: And so many variations.

ZM: Right, right.

MR: I was glad to hear you say about the scales though, because I tell my sax players, "If you can't play your scales, how are you going to look at a chord symbol and figure out what it is?"

ZM: That's right. The scales are the background of the chords. You know, the chords are built on the scale.

MR: Yeah.

ZM: If you're familiar with your scales, it's not that hard. It's not exactly easy at first because you have, in classical music you don't deal with the chords. It's melody line.

MR: Right. But you've got to learn the scales because you were taking classical lessons.

ZM: Yeah.

MR: I've often wondered, part of being a jazz piano player is doing substitution chords sometimes.

ZM: Um hum.

MR: Do you have a method, or can you explain how you choose to switch out one chord for another?

ZM: Well each chord has a substitute neighbor, and you can go from this. And once you learn the what you call foundational chord, you find out, what is the neighbor, what is this called, what is this called. And you go from that. And that way you can find out how to use your substitute chord. It's not done overnight. It takes quite a little while to really absorb that and be proficient enough to do it. You know, if you become familiar with an arrangement and you don't like a chord in there, well now you can substitute something for it but it has to be something harmonically within the arrangement you know. It's the same thing with adding, in other words, adding notes to chords. You know, building, stretching chords out. You have to know when to do this and when not to.

MR: And does it depend on who you are playing behind?

ZM: Sometimes, yes. Because some musicians, some band leaders or whatever, they don't want to hear — they're used to hearing a certain chord. "Hey, man, why you playing that, man? Don't play that." And they'll tell you what they want to hear, you know, because they've been hearing this for God knows how long you know. But that used to bug me in a way because sometimes some of the chord changes, to me, to my ear, they seemed kind of dull you know. And I studied how to lengthen, how to add on notes. And "No man, don't play that." That used to annoy me. But I kind of laid back on it you know. But some guys would want you to do that. You know, would want you to add on or change some notes. Because it gives the particular arrangement, it gives it a different sound.

MR: Yeah. It lets the improviser sort of go a little —

ZM: It stretches his space. Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Do you ever pick up any things from different bass players? Like you might hear them play a certain note in the bass and you go, "Hey, what is that? Let me build a chord on that thing."

ZM: Yeah. And then some guys are so good, there's some bass players out there that are so good, man, they can play the right bass lines and add on different notes, passing chord notes that give the arrangement such a different sound and gives them a little boost in sound. And I like that. But some guys just play what they see there you know. They won't try to. So I asked one guy, I said, "Why do you play the same thing all the time?" He said, "Well man, that's what's written." I says, "Well, okay."

MR: What can you say about that? So you got out of, late 1930s, no, you said you were born in 1925. Okay. So late 1930s, early 1940s, you had to make a decision about what you were going to do.

ZM: Well let's see. I started studying music in '25 — about 1930 I started classical music. And I was playing, you know, playing around. But I didn't get to play any jazz, anything noteworthy until about 1940, '42. And when I started it's like, guys would tell me about — thinking about the chord man, "You're not playing the right chords," you know, saying "you play beautiful runs and things, but you're just not playing the right chords. It's sort of off, and this whole thing's sort of off." And I said, "Okay, man, I'll try to study and make a different arrangement."

MR: Can you name a few of the tunes that you might have been playing back then?

ZM: Oh boy. I don't know. "Sweet Lorraine." "You Can't Give Me Anything but Love," Boy.

MR: And did you have a lead sheet? Like melody and chords? How did you learn the songs?

ZM: Well what I used to depend on, my father, he would go in the music store. And if he heard tunes on the radio, he would buy them and bring them home for me. And I would pick out ones that I liked and play them, and then figure out what I was going to change. And he would tell me, say "Listen, don't try to change the man's melody." I said, "No I'm not going to change his melody I'm just going to add to the chord changes."

MR: That's good. That's good. Using your ears. Yeah.

ZM: Yeah. It wasn't easy. It took quite a little while to cover that, but to do it especially while you're playing, to do it by playing.

MR: Do you remember the first time you got paid to play?

ZM: Jeez. No.

MR: Well it was only about 70 years ago, right?

ZM: No.

MR: But what kind of gigs did you then start to play, after you felt you could.

ZM: Well they were like weekend things, you know like night clubs that had music on the weekend maybe from Friday to Sunday. Because a lot of times some guys that would go upstate like to Buffalo or either Syracuse or White Plains, you know, places like that, and play there for the weekend. In other words we'd go up on a Friday and come back on a Sunday or let's say early Monday morning.

MR: Yeah, you got to watch the sun come up.

ZM: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: It must have been an adventure, because you never know what kind of piano you're going to get.

ZM: True, man. Well the first thing was traveling, because I hadn't done any traveling, you know musically I hadn't done any traveling. And just getting out of New York and seeing the different places, learning these different places, that was sort of a thrill in itself you know. And these groups would be like drums, bass, saxophone and sometimes guitar. And we would work the weekends, Friday night, Saturday and Sunday.

MR: Were people dancing to your music?

ZM: Yeah, sometimes. Yeah, sometimes. Some places they wouldn't allow dancing, now I don't know whether the club owner would tell the people no dancing. And I, to me, I thought that was self-defeating. Because hell if you come in a place and you're going to buy drinks and stuff and the music is good and you want to dance why shouldn't you dance? Long as it's not disturbing anything. But club owners they are a group of people that have their own thinking you know. A lot of times you can't change it. You come into their clubs to play music, you can't — they won't allow you to change their thinking.

MR: Were you old enough to drink then? I'm trying to remember, was the drinking age —

ZM: No, no. And it's a funny thing that you say that. It would always seem like I was the youngest, the baby in the group. And the guy would say, "No, man, like you don't —" And it was some time, man, I played out there before I was able to take a drink. The guys would look out, "No, no, no. You're too young for that."

MR: Yeah, when you're 18 and the other guys are like 21, it seems like a big difference in age.

ZM: Yeah. 25, 28. And they had more experience, traveling on the road and, you know, musically also they had much more experience you know. And they would throw it around. You know if they heard something that wasn't right they'd tell you.

MR: Was there a mixed audience in most of the places you played? Both black and white patrons?

ZM: Not that much, no. Because things were a little difficult at that time. Not that much. Generally the audience was mostly white. There were a few people of color, like would come in, in what you call, but generally the audience was white.

MR: And it would have been considered a jazz club?

ZM: Um hum.

MR: Okay. That's very interesting. Did you have to serve in the military?

ZM: No, I wasn't fortunate enough to get in the military. No.

MR: You weren't fortunate enough to get in? Is that what you said?

ZM: Yeah. Um hum.

MR: Why would you have felt it would have been fortunate?

ZM: Well a lot of it — so many of my friends I had to see off, you know.

MR: Yeah.

ZM: They were going overseas or going to some —

MR: Military base?

ZM: Right a military base to get knowledgeable about how to fight. And it got to me. I felt kind of left out like you know. The guys said, "Man don't worry about it, don't worry, you'll get your chance, don't worry about it."

MR: I wonder if that ended up actually giving you more opportunities to play?

ZM: It did.

MR: Because of the —

ZM: It did. Because I ran into some clubs that had organs. And I'd never played an organ. And boy the first time I had occasion to run into one boy it was a disaster man.

MR: That's a different animal.

ZM: Oh brother. But I'll tell you, once I got the hang of it, you know, what is supposed to happen, I didn't do too bad, I didn't do too bad. In fact as the years went on and whatchacallit, I got married, the lady that I married bought me an organ. Bought me a Hammond B3 and a Leslie speaker. Went down to the store and paid cash. When she told the guy she was going to pay cash, his mouth opened.

MR: And then you've got to move the darn thing, right?

ZM: Well fortunately in this store they had a dolly that fitted on to the —

[door knock]

MR: Did you ever have to, or choose to, work a day job outside music?

ZM: Yeah I've the daytime, yeah. I've worked construction work, I've worked as a shipping clerk, I've worked, let's see, department store. That's about all I can think of right now. But I didn't really like that so much, working, in one thing and then playing after that. That really didn't strike up too good on me.

MR: Yeah. It makes it hard on your family life too.

ZM: But I did it.

MR: Tell me about getting hooked up with Lionel Hampton.

ZM: Well now this was something, a left handed something. My friend, I had a friend, who's a Charleston fellow, from Charleston, South Carolina. He was a trumpet player, a hell of a trumpet player. First chair trumpet player. And he was working in the band, in Lionel's band, and he came to me one day, I was working at a club up in Harlem. He said, "Zeke" he said, "man, listen, this musician, he has an opening for a pianist. He needs a pianist." He said, "Come on, man, come on down. I'll come and pick you up tomorrow and we'll go down to the rehearsal." I said, "Oh man, I don't want to be involved with Hamp." I'd

heard so many things about Hamp you know. And I just, I don't know, I just felt I wouldn't fit in there. He said, "Man, listen, leave it up to me. Let me take — ." He said, "I'll tell you what, I'll be here to pick you up tomorrow at 2:30." And boy he was right there at 2:00 he was at my door. He drove me down to the rehearsal, 48th Street I think it was, I forget, that rehearsal studio. But anyway I went in and he said, "Hey Gates," everybody was Gates. He said, "Come on and play one with me." And the tune he called was "How High the Moon." Well it's a good thing, you know, I had been playing with groups that played some tempos like that you know. And I went right on through it. And he looked around and he said, "All right listen, Gates, pack your bags we're leaving in the morning." And that's how it started man.

MR: He almost didn't give you a chance to say no, right?

ZM: No. Well I'll tell you, I worked with that man 18 years, 18 long God damn days man, or years, I worked with him. And I remember we came from overseas, we had been on a trip like Germany, Switzerland, I can't remember some of the other places right now. But anyway, we came back and I think we were coming to the Port Authority, so he was walking with his wife, and I walked up there and I said, "Hamp," I said, "Listen man, I'm putting my notice in." And he said, "Aw, Gates" he said. And he laughed, ha, ha. He said, "Man I'll call you tomorrow, we'll talk tomorrow. And he laughed it off. I said no, I'm telling you, I'm serious. I said my wife wants me to come in. She wants me to get work within the city. Because I've been out — most of my life we're on the road. Sometimes I'd go out, and we'd stay out three months. You know? So he said, "Man, Zeke, come on." He said, "No, don't break up the group. Don't break up the group." I said, "Hamp I'm sorry, I've got to follow my wife. It's her feeling, she wants me to come in and give it up, traveling. And so that was that. But that man, he browbeat me man for months.

MR: Was this — I can almost picture it. Was this the big band or was it a smaller group?

ZM: The big band, yeah. Because he had a big band and sometimes he didn't use the big band if he would go or something, he would just call me and the bass player. Or sometimes it would just be me — it would just be me and him playing. Or sometimes he'd call me and a bass player and a sax player. You know?

MR: He was a real showman, wasn't he? On stage?

ZM: Yes.

MR: Tell me about some of the stuff he would do.

ZM: He was amazing man. People would be out there looking mean. "Come on, start the music" you know what I mean and all that. And he would just get out there and he'd start playing them vibes and then by the time he'd get through they'd be standing up doing this [stomps] on the floor with their feet. He was amazing. An amazing performer.

MR: Did he come over to the piano on occasion and do his two finger thing?

ZM: Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. And do it very well, man, just like he was playing the vibes.

MR: And he was a drummer too.

ZM: A drummer, yeah. Well his legs were kind of going on him. But up on top, whew. His two hands on top, man, was furious.

MR: So what year did you start with him?

ZM: '45. I think it was the 1940s. 1946 or '47.

MR: Because in the history of jazz books they often mention that he helped get the rhythm & blues thing going, popular. That song he did, "Hey Bop-A-Roo."

ZM: Yeah. He made a fortune off that. I hated that. But he made a fortune. We used to play it every place we played, the band played, that was one of the numbers we played.

MR: And you guys in the band were expected to sing back the thing, right?

ZM: Um hum. Yeah.

MR: You got to know what a bus was like I bet.

ZM: Well fortunately we had a nice bus driver, what was that man's name now, oh boy. But he was a nice man. Because sometimes we'd come into town — he'd bring Hamp and his wife into town and we'd come into town and we would have nowhere to stay. And he'd take that bus and put us on the bus. He'd say "Come on guys, we're going to find a decent hotel." And he'd drive that bus and drive it around until we came up with a hotel. And he saw that everybody was signed in.

MR: More like the road manager, then.

ZM: Yeah, yeah. He was something else. I'll never forget him. As I say I'll never forget him but I forgot the man's name. Yeah. He was something else.

MR: Did you guys have to pay for your own rooms?

ZM: Let's see, yes. Sometimes, and sometimes not. It all depended.

MR: So you were probably putting two and three guys in a room when you could.

ZM: Well at least two in a room, yeah. No we didn't have three but two would be in a room mostly. He'd try to give us single rooms. Because a lot of the guys didn't like doubling up. Me? I was one of them. I didn't like that doubling up.

MR: Okay. When you went to do records with the Hampton group, was it a lot of time pressure to get in so many songs in one session?

ZM: Well no, not really. Because these were tunes that we'd been playing. Most of the time it was tunes — then we'd have about three or four tunes in there that some of the guys wrote or some other composer wrote that we would install in there. But generally it would be tunes that, well from the popular tunes of the day you know, or let's say of the era.

MR: Yeah.

ZM: And most of the recording didn't take that long, it didn't take that long if I can remember.

MR: Who were the vocalists that sang with the band while you were there?

ZM: Oh boy, that's another thing he changed. There were so many different women vocalists, I can't even remember one name now.

MR: Was Dinah Washington?

ZM: Yeah, Dinah, yeah. Dinah was there for a while. I called her — she was just getting ready to leave. She told me, she said, "Zeke," she said, "I'm sorry, I'm so sorry that I have to leave." She said, "You're some piano player," she said, "but I can't contend with this man."

MR: And what about Joe Williams? I know he was with Hampton for a while but it might have been —

ZM: Yeah. He was there for a little while when I first came there, yeah. He's a nice guy.

MR: Well what was it — people talk about Benny Goodman being difficult to deal with. Was it the same with Hampton? What was hard?

ZM: Well Goodman, well Goodman he wasn't difficult to deal with, all he expected of you. And he would tell you when you come to play, he'd say, "I expect you to play my music, play it well." That's what he — "I expect you to play my music, play it well." And he said, "Good luck." Now Hamp, Hamp was difficult. When I came with him he said, "Gates," he say, "you play very well," he said, "but you know just follow me." He said, "just accompany me" he said, "you know, see that you have a nice chord feeling behind me while I'm soloing." You know. And that's how we worked down through the years. And boy I'll never forget how that man hounded me. He hounded me for months.

MR: About the way you were accompanying?

ZM: No. When I told him I put my notice in.

MR: No, man, you can't leave, right?

ZM: Boy he just kept — I guess he figured he was going to break me down. He must have had that idea in his mind. But I told him, I said, "I gave some serious thought to it. Most of my time out here, when I got married, my wife, she adored that I gave most of my time to the band." I said, "Now she's telling me, 'I want you to come in to New York and just work around in New York'" you know, or wherever. I said that's what I got to do, man.

MR: If you had wanted a raise in the Hampton band, did you have to go through Gladys?

ZM: Sometimes.

MR: Yeah.

ZM: In fact, most times.

MR: Were you ever successful in getting a raise?

ZM: Yeah. She was, one thing about her, she was a really stern businesswoman but you know, if she saw that you knew your job and what you were doing was good for the band, she wouldn't stand in the way. She wouldn't stand in the way. And she'd tell Hamp, she'd

say, you know, "let me offer these musicians — let them exhibit their talents as they can" you know.

MR: Did you ever stop while you were doing that with Hampton, stop and think about what kind of salary would I be making in a day job as opposed to what I'm doing now?

ZM: I would imagine in some industries I would making probably maybe about $50 to $100, maybe $200 more, possibly. But I wasn't doing too bad, I wasn't doing too bad.

MR: I read that you played at the White House three times.

ZM: Yeah. Well no, about four times. Eisenhower, Bush, what's the other, what's the man that's been there so long?

MR: Reagan?

ZM: Oh yeah, Reagan, we did play for him. And the last man, the man that's been there — Roosevelt.

MR: You played for Roosevelt. Wow.

ZM: Um hum.

MR: Well I bet you got a good piano when you went to the White House.

ZM: Oh yes, yes. The piano, one, in fact twice, Bosendorfer pianos. Oh. Boy what a keyboard. I'll never forget — I sure would have loved to have one of them pianos.

MR: Yeah.

ZM: You know including the Steinway, and that's the top of the market. It makes a Steinway sound like a toy.

MR: Well maybe you could trade your Hammond B 3 in for a Bosendorfer.

ZM: Yeah that's some piano, man.

MR: So when you got off the Hampton band, then you sort of had to re-establish your reputation.

ZM: Back in the City, yeah. Well that wasn't too hard to do you know, because club owners are funny. All they're interested in is seeing the cash register ring. As long as the cash register keeps on ringing, most of them, they just go on about their business doing whatever they're going to do. Some of them are musicians themselves. They just go on. Now if you kind of slack down and you ain't doing the job now they'll let you know, let you know quick.

MR: What did you think of the late 40s and the early 50s with Dizzy and Charlie Parker and —

ZM: Oh, I respect those guys highly. Boy they were tremendous musicians, Dizzy and Bird. And they started something man. It was artistic. They started something. Yeah.

MR: And Thelonious Monk

ZM: Monk yeah.

MR: You like Monk?

ZM: I'll tell you, at first, when I first heard him, I kind of stepped back, damn, man. Just like a lot of other people. But he was the master of his fate. He knew his music, and he played his music. I would call him a genius. I would go that far. There's so many tunes that he composed man that were hell of a jazz tune, and they'll be around a long time. They'll be played a long time.

MR: So in the last twenty or thirty years for you, do you mostly wait for the phone to ring as far as gigs?

ZM: Sometimes. Yeah. Sometimes. But sometimes — music is funny. It's a lot of heads you're playing here or heads you're playing there or somebody recommends you to out there, and different situations happen like that.

MR: Did you ever be a band leader?

ZM: Yes.

MR: And then you have to go out and find the gigs, right?

ZM: Yeah. It was all right. Because then you get to dictate what you want to play you know, mostly.

MR: How did rock & roll affect your employment as a musician?

ZM: Well I'll tell you about rock & roll. I can't say I have the greatest respect for it because a lot of times it's very disorganized, the music that is.

MR: Really? Disorganized?

ZM: Um hum.

MR: I never heard that sort of term.

ZM: I don't know, a lot of the guys that play it don't seem to have, you know like you talk to a jazz musician and you talk to a rock musician. And some of these young guys man, the ideas they have you wouldn't believe it. One guy told me he said, "Brushes, I don't use no God damn brushes, man. Brushes, that's for idiots." I said, "Well how do you go and work?" I said, "You ain't going to work too much, man." Because brushes are an important part of drums. "How are you going to work?"

MR: That's such a simple statement, it's so important. Because sometimes people don't take that into account.

ZM: Well yeah. I said, "Man you ain't going to work too much, too often." That's an important part of the drums. And some guys that play them play them very well, very good at it.

MR: When you were leading your own band and playing gigs if people came up and requested a current rock tune or something, what did you do?

ZM: Well you know sometimes, sometimes we could play it because I had a drummer working with me, Richard — aw I forget the man's last name. Anyway, he could play Dixieland, he could play rock, he could play jazz, blues. He knew that God damn drumset

so good and knew the rhythms. That's the important thing. He knew those rhythms and he would play them and play them comfortable. So if they asked for a rock tune, what I would do, I had some blues/rock things with the background, and I would play them. "Oh yeah, you played rock." I said, "Yeah, we play rock."

MR: Yeah. Like Ramsey Lewis was playing rock. You know? He just took songs and sort of put a rock beat to it.

ZM: The man was a hell of a pianist. Yeah. There's really nothing difficult, but the main thing is the rhythm. If you're a pianist or you are a drummer or a bass player and you have that rhythm in your mind, you feel it you know, you can play it. Because it's music, it's compatible music. When you figure it all out it's music.

MR: Did you have a favorite span of years in your life where things were good at home, your work was good, the country seemed to be not in crisis.

ZM: Yeah, yeah. I know what you mean. I've gone through that, yeah. Work was just coming in, sometimes you have to turn some people down and say I'll catch you next round you know. Yeah. But I don't know, music is like that. Just like that. Sometimes you come to where everybody's coming out, especially in the warm weather, coming out and they want to go to night clubs and dance. Yeah.

MR: What do you put on, who do you listen to at home, if anybody?

ZM: Well I listen to Coltrane, I listen to Bird, Dizzy, Horace Silver — you notice only jazz musicians. Yeah, I listen to them very carefully. I don't try to copy nothing what they're doing but I listen very careful. If I'm going to use it I take it and turn it around just so much, so that it don't sound like exactly what this guy's doing.

MR: Just like all those years ago when your father brought you that sheet music and you started like messing with it.

ZM: Yeah. Get in there with the tunes and play them down a couple of times and let me see now this first chord I think I'll add on the ninth or add on the eleventh. But sometimes I would have to change it because some guys would say, "Listen man, that chord don't sound just right, I don't hear it." I say, "All right, man, okay, all right."

MR: "I'll save that for the next group I play in," right? And see if it works there. Well I'm looking forward to hearing you later today, and I think we'll have a good time. And it's been fascinating talking to you.

ZM: Yeah. Yeah I've been out here man, all these years. I've been all over the world. I've been to Europe about seven, eight, nine times. Been to the Far East about six times. Been to Russia about four or five times. All these different places. And I can't say that I was able to get around and really maneuver in these places, but I've been there. I played there. Yeah.

MR: Yeah. It's pretty amazing that people around the world all respond to this American music.

ZM: Yeah. This is something. You can go to Russia and not be able to speak a word of Russian, but you get on that bandstand and you start playing, and people come right up, come right around the band, shaking your hand. And they'll be talking and you don't know what the hell they're saying but they enjoy the music. The music pulls them in regardless of not being able to let's say understand with each other what they are saying you know, but the music. And I always talk about that. Man, if you play the music, just play it. Play it right and you ain't – you'll never have any trouble. And you'd be surprised the people that you will enjoy, or will enjoy it with you. You know, because of the feeling of that music.

MR: Well that's a good note to end on. All right.

ZM: Well I hope that you remember all I said to you, because I think that's probably one of our — we don't get enough publicity. A lot of people don't even know about us. And I'm hoping every year, I'm hoping that the tide will turn.

MR: Well that's part of the reason why we're doing this. So thanks a lot for talking to me today.

ZM: Yeah. I appreciate it man.